The Pagan Kingdom collapsed after a Mongol invasion in 1286 and Arakan broke away at the same time as the rest of Burma fragmented. By the 1750s the Burmese kings had again become a major regional power and made significant gains in a series of wars with neighbouring Siam.[13] Flush with success, they then invaded and conquered Arakan in 1784. It has been estimated that around 30,000 Muslims fled Arakan during the brief forty years of Burmese rule.[14] Unfortunately for the Burmese, their control of Arakan brought them into direct conflict with British-ruled India. In the First Anglo-Burmese War, Britain annexed Arakan in 1826. After two more wars, by 1886 all of Burma was ruled by the British (administratively as if it was part of India). In 1937 it was made a full colony in its own right (on the basis of the pre-1824 borders) and it became independent, in that particular geographical form, in 1948.

All of this matters for the simple reason that the regime, Buddhist extremists and Burmese nationalists now have a fixation on who was or was not living within these artificial borders in 1824–6.[15] While this is nonsense under the UN conventions on citizenship,[16] they are also inaccurate in their account of history.

It is thus useful to set out some of the historical record about the ethnic make-up of Arakan both before 1826 and during the period of British colonial rule. The available evidence suggests that a group speaking an Indo–Aryan language[17] migrated from northern India to Arakan in around 3000 BC. As will be discussed in Chapter 1, this group can be identified with the modern-day Rohingyas, and by 1000 AD they had largely adopted Islam and their language had absorbed other influences (from their trading across the Bay of Bengal) to the extent that it had diverged significantly from its original form.[18] When Arakan again split from the rest of Burma after 1300 AD, it became a multi-confessional (Hinduism, Islam and Buddhism were all present), multi-ethnic state. Most of its rulers were Muslims and the kingdom had close links (and enduring rivalries) with the Bengali kingdom to its north as well as with the various kingdoms in central Burma. Overall, as we will discuss in some detail, there is substantial evidence that an ethnic group, now known as the Rohingyas, lived in Arakan before the Burmese invasion of 1784.[19]

To address the charge of the extremists that the Rohingyas only arrived in Arakan during the period of British rule, it is useful to examine the